

A friend asks you for a favor you don't want to do

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

A plain no is a complete answer. For something small you can give any short, ordinary reason, or none, and not wanting to help says nothing bad about you.

THE GOAL

You're answering honestly instead of agreeing just to end the moment. Say the word **no** straight out, then keep your reason to one short line.

CHECKLIST

You've just been asked for something, and you're about to answer.

- ☐ Catch it if part of you is agreeing just to end the moment, before the yes comes out.
- ☐ Say the word **no** in your first sentence, plainly, not just implied by the rest of what you say.
- ☐ Keep your reason to one short sentence, then stop talking. A second or third reason is **over-explaining**, not extra persuasion.
- ☐ For something genuinely small, give any short, ordinary reason and leave it there.
- ☐ If you actually want to help a different way, name **one specific thing** you'll do, in the same breath.
- ☐ Unless you already know exactly how and when, skip promising to make it up to them.
- ☐ Tell the person directly, not through someone else.
- ☐ Use your normal tone. Don't switch to extra-formal or extra-sweet to cushion it.
- ☐ If they push back once, repeat your no instead of reaching for a new reason.
- ☐ Let the silence sit for a second after you've said no, instead of rushing to fill it.
- ☐ Once you've answered, move the conversation on, ask them something else, or go back to what you were doing.
- ☐ Right afterward, skip checking in to see if they're upset.
- ☐ If their reaction genuinely hasn't eased up after a few days, say so plainly and ask what's going on, instead of guessing.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 You're bracing for a worse reaction than you'll get.
- 2 Refusing only costs you socially when the favor would have been **cheap to grant**.
- 3 Don't agree just to keep the peace. That almost never protects the friendship the way it feels like it should.

What refusing actually costs you

KNOW

You're bracing for a worse reaction than you'll get.

Overestimating protects you: guessing too harsh costs little, but being caught unprepared by a worse reaction costs more. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Refusing only costs you socially when the favor would have been **cheap to grant**.

People size up your refusal by what it would have saved you, not by the refusal on its own. [Source 2](#)

WATCH

Turning someone down can make you look more assertive, but also a little less respected. The assertive part doesn't fade, even when the favor would have been expensive to grant.

That's the assertive side of the trade, and it doesn't shrink the way the respect side does once the favor gets expensive to refuse. [Source 2](#)

What your no actually needs

SAY

A short, ordinary reason like "I'm busy" is the norm for turning someone down. People almost never explain themselves at all when they say yes.

So stop hunting for a stronger reason: save the real explaining for the asks that call for it. [Source 3](#)

SAY

Deciding your exact words ahead of time, like "I'd rather not," makes you feel freer to actually say them when the moment comes.

Just being told you're allowed to say no doesn't stick the same way as already knowing exactly what you'd say. [Source 4](#)

What each answer sets in motion

WATCH

Saying yes now doesn't only answer this ask. It can set the terms for what gets asked of you later.

The effect held even when a stranger made the second, unrelated request weeks after the first. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

About half of what looks like generosity is reluctant compliance. **You're not the exception** here.

Direct, in-person requests are hard to refuse once you're standing there, so avoiding the situation ahead of time is what actually works. [Source 6](#)

DON'T

Don't agree just to keep the peace. That almost never protects the friendship the way it feels like it should.

Feeling pressured into a yes tends to breed resentment instead of gratitude, the opposite of what keeping the peace was supposed to buy you. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Turning a friend down, even for a good reason, changes how they see the relationship from then on.

ACTUALLY

People about to refuse consistently **predict a bigger hit to the friendship** than the friend who was turned down reports feeling. [Source 1](#)

Sources

1. <https://gwern.net/doc/psychology/2022-lu.pdf>
2. <https://pamela-k-smith.squarespace.com/s/YinSmith-When-and-how-refusing-to-help-decreases-ones-influence.pdf>
3. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10115833/>
4. <https://www.nature.com/articles/s41598-023-50532-3>
5. https://web.mit.edu/curhan/www/docs/Articles/15341_Readings/Influence_Compliance/Freedman_Fraser_Foot-in-the-door.pdf
6. <http://jasondana.net/docs/2014%20Cain%20Dana%20Newman.pdf>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Saying no and holding a line at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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